Term Project Data and Metadata Profile: Oscar Director Winners Dataset

For my term project, I selected a dataset that includes every Academy Award Best Director nominee and winner from 1930 to 2019. It brings together both demographic and historical information on each director. My goal was to examine how representation in Hollywood has changed—or stayed the same—over these ninety years, and the Oscars seemed like the ideal perspective. Best Director stands out in particular; it's a category that highlights creative leadership and shows who actually gets to direct major films. By analyzing nomination and win trends, I can trace where there's been progress and where diversity gaps remain within the industry. Over the decades, for example, very few women or directors of color were recognized, while in recent years there have been small but notable increases in representation, making these trends particularly interesting to explore.

The information is fairly straightforward. Each entry lists a director or directing team, along with the year, name, gender, race, film, and whether they won or were only nominated. Occasionally, more than one person directed a film—these situations are recorded either as joint entries or as separate rows, depending on how the data was structured. The simplicity of the table makes it easy to scan for patterns or conduct statistical analysis, while still providing enough detail to examine both individual achievements and broader industry trends.

Priyanka Dobhal compiled this resource and made it available on data.world. Most of the award details appear to come from official Academy records, but the exact sources are unclear, and no formal citations are provided. No license is specified; users are asked to credit Dobhal, but it is uncertain whether the information can be redistributed or used commercially. These gaps make it difficult to assess reliability or determine what actions are permitted. Understanding who relies on this information—and how it is used—highlights why clarity and proper documentation are so important, particularly when the data may be used in academic work, journalism, or educational settings.

A variety of stakeholders find this resource valuable. Dobhal's organizational choices shape how the information appears, while the Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences has an indirect stake in its usage. Researchers, students, film historians, journalists, and educators all rely on it to explore trends in recognition and diversity. Journalists analyze patterns in award recognition over time, educators develop assignments and visualizations showing shifts in Hollywood, and digital humanists or data analysts often combine this with other film data—such as box office performance, critical reception, or award histories from other categories—to examine how representation and creative leadership have evolved over decades. In addition, students and independent researchers can use this dataset to generate infographics or timelines highlighting historic achievements or disparities, adding context to discussions about inclusion in the film industry.

The data is provided as a single CSV file, contained in one table that can be opened in Excel, Google Sheets, or LibreOffice Calc. For more advanced analysis, it can be imported into R or Python without specialized software. Its format also allows integration with other film industry information, enabling analyses and visualizations that reveal broader patterns within Hollywood. Because of this flexibility, the dataset could support a variety of projects, from comparing recognition across different awards to exploring links between critical acclaim, box office success, and director demographics.

Access is straightforward, though the compilation isn't flawless. Column headers provide basic descriptions—award year, director's gender, race, name, film, and nomination/win status—but there's no explanation of how demographic categories were determined. Did the directors self-identify, or were values inferred? What specific terms were used? None of this is clarified. Version tracking and formal metadata are missing, which limits transparency and makes it difficult to connect this information with other sources. More detailed documentation—including precise definitions for demographic terms, clarification on how co-directors are handled, and a complete data dictionary—would improve usability. Formal metadata standards, such as Dublin Core or DDI, could make the dataset easier to discover, cite, and integrate into broader research projects. Standardized keywords would also enhance searchability and ensure long-term value.

No academic paper has cited this exact compilation, but similar Oscar statistics are frequently used in studies on diversity and representation in Hollywood. Its structure is well suited for tracking recognition for Best Director over time, supporting digital humanities projects, visualizations of historical patterns, or detailed research on gender and racial representation. Analysts could explore whether disparities have narrowed, whether certain studios or genres are favored, or whether nomination and win trends align with broader industry and societal shifts. Additional questions could examine how repeat winners or nominated directors compare across decades, or whether new directors break into recognition at similar rates. While this resource doesn't provide every answer, it offers opportunities to examine systemic bias, shifts in film leadership, and the relationship between industry choices and cultural change.

Overall, this compilation provides a clear, user-friendly record of Best Director nominees and winners from 1930 to 2019. It is accessible and straightforward, yet limited metadata, uncertain provenance, and unclear licensing reduce transparency and trustworthiness. With comprehensive documentation and proper metadata, this resource could become a far more powerful tool for analyzing recognition and representation in the film industry. Enhanced clarity and structure would allow future researchers, educators, and analysts to explore patterns more confidently and make stronger, data-driven observations about inclusion, leadership, and creative influence in Hollywood.

References

Kaggle. Dobhal, Priyanka. (2023). *Oscar-Winning Directors Analysis, Examining Gender, Race and Director Trends from 1930-2019*. https://www.kaggle.com/datasets/thedevastator/oscar-winning-directors-analysis

Data World. Dobhal, Priyanka. (2023). https://data.world/priyankad0993

Term Project: Repository Profile
DaSCH – Swiss National Data and Service Center for the Humanities
Repository URL: https://dasch.swiss

Introduction

I'm evaluating if DaSCH—the Swiss National Data and Service Center for the Humanities—is a suitable home for the Oscar Winning Directors Analysis dataset from Kaggle. This dataset tracks Best Director Oscar winners from 1930 to 2019. Each entry includes the year, gender, race, director's name, film title, and whether they were nominees or winners. It's a useful resource for research into gender and racial disparities, film history, or trends in representation in cinema.

1. Repository Policies & Procedures

DaSCH began in 2017, managed by the Swiss Academy of Humanities and Social Sciences (SAGW), and since 2021 it's been mainly funded by the Swiss National Science Foundation (SNSF). The Digital Humanities Lab at the University of Basel and other partner universities played a key role in its creation.

What distinguishes DaSCH is that it's designed for long-term preservation and open access to research data in the humanities. Its infrastructure is made for digital humanities projects, supporting things like sustainable storage, semantic data modeling, and interoperability using linked data. There's a strong emphasis on the FAIR data principles: Findable, Accessible, Interoperable, and Reusable. That's where research is heading.

Their policies focus on a few main points:
- Long-term preservation
- Structured, semantically rich metadata
- Persistent identifiers
- Interoperable standards
- Expert data curation

The website details DaSCH's governance, funding, and national service role—especially its support for Swiss humanities research.

2. Is DaSCH a Good Fit for My Dataset?

I think so—DaSCH's mission fits well with what my dataset offers.

Oscar-winning directors is a subject at the heart of the humanities. It's relevant to film studies, media studies, gender studies, and cultural history—all areas DaSCH supports. My data is already in CSV format, which works with DaSCH's systems. The dataset could also be enhanced with semantic modeling—for example, linking directors to films, years, awards, and

demographic details. The focus on representation in cinema ties directly into current digital humanities conversations.

While the data comes from Kaggle and isn't Switzerland-specific, the topic is still well aligned with DaSCH's mission. There may be some eligibility criteria to check, but overall, it's a strong conceptual match.

3. Is the Repository Open to General Submissions?

DaSCH isn't open to everyone. It follows a specific collection scope, focused on supporting the Swiss research infrastructure.

<u>Collection Scope</u>
DaSCH primarily serves:
- Swiss research institutions
- Projects funded or recognized by Swiss research organizations
- Humanities and social science projects that require sustainable data management

You can think of it as a national service center, not a crowd-sourced platform like Kaggle or Zenodo.

<u>Who Can Contribute?</u>
Typically, eligible contributors include:
- Researchers affiliated with Swiss universities
- Projects funded by the Swiss National Science Foundation (SNSF)
- Humanities research groups working directly with DaSCH

So, if you are part of a Swiss research institution and working on a formal humanities project—maybe film history, maybe representation studies—DaSCH is suitable. But if you are an independent researcher with no formal Swiss affiliation, your submission probably won't be automatically accepted.

4. Submission Information Package (SIP)

DaSCH does not use OAIS terms like "Submission Information Package (SIP)" in its terminology, but its submission process aligns with OAIS principles.

To submit, you need:
- Your dataset in a supported format (such as CSV, XML, or a structured database)
- Structured metadata, including:
  - Dataset title
  - Creator(s)
  - Project description

  - Methodology
  - Provenance
  - Licensing details
- Documentation about the data structure and variables
- In some cases, a data model that fits DaSCH's semantic framework (usually RDF or linked data)

DaSCH places a strong emphasis on semantic data modeling and ontologies. Your metadata has to comply with specific internal schemas and linked data standards. Simply uploading a CSV file is not sufficient. You will likely need onboarding and guidance to prepare your data in the required structure.

5. Human Assistance and Consulting

DaSCH is distinguished by its hands-on support.

As a national infrastructure, it provides:
- Consulting
- Technical onboarding
- Assistance with data modeling
- Support for long-term preservation

This is a significant advantage. Unlike general repositories where you are left to manage submissions alone, DaSCH collaborates with research teams to ensure the data is high-quality, sustainable, and interoperable.

So, for your dataset, you can expect real guidance—such as transforming a flat CSV into a semantically rich data structure (for example, Director → Film → Award Year relationships), getting help with persistent identifiers, or using controlled vocabularies for categories like gender and race.

6. Metadata Standards

DaSCH puts a strong emphasis on structured metadata and ensuring its data integrates smoothly with other systems. Although you won't see a single schema like Dublin Core specifically listed on their website, the platform relies on semantic web technologies, linked data, and ontologies. In practice, this means their metadata must conform to specific internal models, likely aligned with international standards for humanities data. Everything is organized, machine-readable, and built for easy sharing.

If I were preparing my dataset for DaSCH, I'd need to provide things like:
- Controlled vocabularies for gender and race
- Authority files for directors

- Standardized film titles
- Well-defined fields for temporal data (such as the award year)

7. Data Access Mechanisms

Is Login Required?
Generally, DaSCH allows access to published datasets without requiring you to log in. Some collections do have restrictions, usually due to project agreements, but most of the available data can be downloaded openly. Access to restricted data would require registration, probably through an institutional account.

Access Options
DaSCH offers several methods for accessing data:
- Web interfaces for browsing
- Structured data queries
- Downloadable files
- Potential API access for structured data feeds

Since DaSCH is based on semantic web principles, it is built for machine-readable and query-based access—using structured endpoints. This is a significant advantage over platforms like Kaggle, which mainly provide files for download and little else.

8. Dissemination Information Package (DIP)

According to OAIS terminology, DaSCH's Dissemination Information Package includes:
- The dataset itself in a usable format
- Structured metadata
- Persistent identifiers
- Documentation explaining the dataset contents
- Licensing information
- Possibly machine-readable semantic exports

DaSCH emphasizes interoperability, so users receive more than just the raw data—they also get the context needed to understand and use it.

Conclusion
DaSCH, the Swiss National Data and Service Center for the Humanities, is a robust, well-supported research data infrastructure focused on humanities projects. It offers long-term preservation, semantic data modeling, rigorous metadata standards, and consulting services.

For the Oscar-winning directors dataset from Kaggle, DaSCH is an excellent match because of its humanities focus, support for rich and structured data, alignment with FAIR data principles, and strong preservation capabilities. The limitation is that it isn't entirely open to everyone; it

primarily serves projects affiliated with Swiss institutions. So, eligibility depends on your institutional connection and the nature of your project.

Compared to general-purpose repositories, DaSCH offers superior preservation and more detailed metadata. For a formal digital humanities project—such as analyzing representation in film history—it's an ideal archival choice, provided you meet their submission criteria.

Additional Required Information

1. Recommended Data Citation

Citation for Original Dataset
Dobhal, Priyanka. *Oscar-Winning Directors Analysis (1930–2019)*. Kaggle. https://www.kaggle.com/datasets/thedevastator/oscar-winning-directors-analysis [schema.datacite.org]

Citation for Student-Curated Dataset
Oscar Best Director Dataset (1930–2019). Student-created dataset for academic coursework, 2026. GitHub: https://github.com/castle0929/Oscar-Director-Dataset

2. Long-Term Preservation Considerations

File Format Sustainability

- **Excel (.xlsx)** is a proprietary Microsoft format and may become difficult to access in the distant future. Converting to **.csv** would reduce long-term risk.
- **PDF (.pdf)** is highly stable and widely supported for long-term use.
- **XML (.xml)**, including the DataCite metadata file, is an open standard and preservation-friendly.

Software Needed to Open Files

- .xlsx → Microsoft Excel, Google Sheets, or LibreOffice
- .pdf → Any PDF reader (Adobe, Preview, browser)
- .xml → Any text editor or code editor (Notepad, VS Code, etc.)

Risks & Mitigations

- Proprietary formats carry longevity risks → Mitigate with archival copies in open formats like CSV or TXT.
- Ensure future readability by documenting schema and metadata clearly (your DataCite file helps with this).

3. Copyright License

This dataset and associated materials are shared under:
Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International (CC BY 4.0)
This license allows reuse, redistribution, and adaptation, provided proper attribution is given.
It is appropriate because the underlying dataset is publicly accessible and intended for analytical and educational reuse.

4. Human Subjects Considerations

This dataset carries **no human subjects concerns** because:

- All information is about **public figures** (film directors).
- All information is **publicly available** through Academy records and the Kaggle dataset source.
- The dataset contains **no personally identifiable sensitive data** (no contact information, addresses, financial data, etc.).
- No anonymization steps were needed.
- There are no privacy, consent, or IRB considerations.

This dataset is ethically safe for public sharing, analysis, and educational use.